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Fields of Interest

Primary: Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics, Game Theory

Secondary: Econometric Theory

Education

- 2023–2027 **Ph.D. in Economics**, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
Dissertation: “Communication and Coordination under Incomplete Information: Theory and Experiment”
- 2026 **Visiting Scholar**, Department of Economics, Purdue University
Hosts: Timothy Cason and Matthew Kovach
- 2026 **Visiting Scholar**, Division of the Humanities and Social Sciences, California Institute of Technology
Host: Marina Agranov
- 2021–2023 **M.Phil. in Economics**, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
Thesis: “Binary Quantile Selection Model” (advisors: Songnian Chen and Junlong Feng)
- 2019–2021 **M.Sc. in Economics**, The Chinese University of Hong Kong (Shenzhen)
- 2015–2019 **B.A. in Economics**, Renmin University of China

References (Thesis Committee)

Wooyoung Lim (Ph.D. Supervisor)
Department Head, Professor, Lee Heng Fellow
Department of Economics
Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
wooyoung@ust.hk

Yeon-Koo Che
Kelvin J. Lancaster Professor of Economic Theory
Department of Economics
Columbia University
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Rui Tang
Associate Professor, Lee Heng Fellow
Department of Economics
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Songfa Zhong
Chair Professor
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Job Market Paper

“**Role Uncertainty and Punishment Severity in Repeated Cheap Talk: Theory and Experiment**,” with Wooyoung Lim.

*Revise and Resubmit, **Games and Economic Behavior**.*

We investigate the efficacy of the shadow of the future in sustaining information transmission under partially aligned interests by manipulating two institutional features: punishment severity and role uncertainty. While theory suggests that these features potentially facilitate fully revealing equilibria relative to a baseline of fixed

roles and mild punishment, our experiment documents an asymmetric effect on sender and receiver behavior. Harsh punishment with fixed roles disciplines senders but fails to elicit trust from receivers. Conversely, mild punishment with role uncertainty fosters trust rather than honesty, supporting an outcome where senders obtain their preferred action without needing to be truthful. The combination of both features asymmetrically improves subjects' honesty as senders but discourages their trust as receivers. Our findings imply that mechanisms aiming for truthful and efficient communication must carefully tailor incentives for both roles, rather than relying solely on disciplining the informed sender.

Funded by an RPG Student Research Grant, Department of Economics, HKUST.

Working Papers

“First They Came for the Others: A Theory of Divide-and-Conquer,” with Yeon-Koo Che and Wooyoung Lim.

Divide-and-conquer tactics often succeed not through mechanical coordination failures, but through epistemic friction regarding an aggressor's underlying intent. When an attacker strikes a first target, bystanders must infer whether the assault represents a localized grievance or a systemic campaign. If the attack is rationally interpreted as particularized, bystanders abstain, prompting the isolated victim to surrender. We demonstrate how higher attack costs and lower correlation between victims' fates facilitate this division, and then study how behavioral responses, rhetoric, treaty commitments, and downstream defense networks modify this inference.

“Binary Quantile Selection Model,” with Songnian Chen and Junlong Feng.

This paper is the first to study the identification and estimation of a linear quantile regression model subject to endogenous sample selection with binary outcome variables. We model the endogenous sample selection by a copula function with a low-dimensional unknown parameter vector, characterize the semi-parametric identification conditions, and propose an easy-to-implement three-step estimation method. The key steps include estimating the copula parameters by a non-linear least squares estimation (NLLS) with local smoothing given estimators of quantile parameters at the post-selection quantile levels, and then estimating the quantile parameters at the pre-selection quantile levels by a smoothed maximum score estimation (SMS) given the estimated copula parameters. We also show that the estimator is consistent and asymptotically normal. A simple Monte Carlo simulation illustrates that our estimator has reasonably good finite sample properties.

Work in Progress

“First They Came for the Others: An Experiment of Divide-and-Conquer,” with Yeon-Koo Che and Wooyoung Lim. *Preparing for pre-registration.*

A three-player laboratory test of the inference channel, varying the cost of aggression and the prior probability of a systemic attacker across three environments, with additional phases on propaganda under high and low reputation costs, on pre-game provocation, and on publicly revealed trust-game records.

“Incentivizing Teamwork: An Experiment,” with Timothy Cason. *Preparing for pre-registration.*

A 2×2 test of two transparency margins in team incentive contracts—observability of effort (simultaneous vs. sequential) and observability of pay (public vs. mediated)—comparing the cost-effectiveness of four unique-implementation mechanisms against a symmetric Nash benchmark.

“Correlation Sensitivity in Social Context: Theory and Experiment,” with Hendrik Rommeswinkel. *Experimental interface in development.*

A representation of “fear of missing out” that nests individual regret aversion and social regret aversion as

sensitivity to the correlation structure of social outcomes, tested through a novel same-marginal lottery-of-allocations (SMLoA) tasks that separate the two channels.

Conference and Seminar Presentations

2026	European Meeting of the Econometric Society (University College Dublin, scheduled) Midwest Economic Theory Conference (Ohio State University) Ostrom-Smith Conference on Experimental and Behavioral Economics (Purdue University) Asian Meeting of the Econometric Society, China (University of Hong Kong) Hong Kong Economic Association (University of Macau) HKUST Ph.D. Student Conference <i>Internal seminars:</i> California Institute of Technology; Purdue University
2025	ESA Asia-Pacific Regional Conference (Osaka University) 3rd Science of Decision Making Conference (SWUFE)
2024	ESA Asia-Pacific Regional Conference (Nanyang Technological University) 7th World Congress of the Game Theory Society (Peking University)
2023	Shanghai Advanced Workshop of Econometrics (SUFE)

Teaching Experience

Duties included: tutorial sessions, office hours, grading.

Teaching Assistant, HKUST

2022, 2023, 2025	Applied Econometrics (M.Sc.)
2023, 2024, 2025	Econometrics (Ph.D.)
2023, 2024, 2025	Empirical Methods for Economics Analysis (DBA)
2024	Microeconomic Analysis (M.Sc.)

Teaching Assistant, The Chinese University of Hong Kong (Shenzhen)

2021	Advanced Econometrics II (Ph.D.)
2020	Introductory Econometrics (Undergraduate)

Teaching Assistant, Renmin University of China

2019	Macroeconomics (Undergraduate)
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Research Experience

2024–2025	Research Assistant , School of Business and Management, HKUST. Undergraduate program data analysis for Prof. Melody Chao (Associate Director of UG Programs) and Prof. Allen Huang (Associate Dean of UG Programs).
2020	Research Assistant , School of Management and Economics, CUHK (Shenzhen). Machine learning and density forecasting for Prof. Liyu Dou.
2018–2019	Research Assistant , School of Economics, Renmin University of China. Global value chain analysis for Prof. Zhanming Chen and Prof. Xiaohua Xia

Honors and Awards

2026	RedBird Academic Excellence Award, HKUST
2025	University Global Research Award, HKUST
2025–2026	University Research Travel Grant, HKUST (×2)
2023–2024	Departmental Research Travel Grant, HKUST (×2)
2023	Departmental Research Grant, HKUST
2023	RedBird Ph.D. Award, HKUST
2021–present	Research Postgraduate Scholarship, HKUST
2021	Presidential Award of Outstanding Graduate Student, CUHK (Shenzhen)
2021	First-class Academic Excellence Award, CUHK (Shenzhen)
2021	Dean’s List, CUHK (Shenzhen)
2021	Second-class Subject Prize (No. 2): Advanced Microeconomics, CUHK (Shenzhen)
2019–2020	First-class Subject Prizes (No. 1 ×3): Advanced Macroeconomics, International Finance, Advanced Monetary Economics, CUHK (Shenzhen)
2019	Gold Entrance Scholarship, CUHK (Shenzhen)
2019	Outstanding Graduate Student, School of Economics, Renmin University of China
2018	Second-class Scholarship, Renmin University of China
2016	Third-class Scholarship, Renmin University of China

Skills

Experimental	oTree (Python, HTML, CSS, JavaScript); design and implementation of laboratory and online experiments
Statistical	R, Stata, MATLAB, $\LaTeX$
Languages	Mandarin Chinese (native), English (fluent)

Pre-doctoral Publications (in Chinese)

2020	Huang, J., X. Xia, and Z. Chen. “Impacts of global value chain on spatial transfer of ecological elements: A case study of virtual water use for iPhone 6.” <i>Acta Ecologica Sinica</i> (Chinese Science Citation Database), 40(7): 2473–2488.
2019	Xia, X. and J. Huang. “Industrial division and ecological factor accounting under global value chain: A literature review.” <i>Journal of China University of Petroleum (Social Science)</i> , 35(2): 1–16.